Toyota Techstream — Data Acquisition Steps

Vehicle Control History, PCS Freeze Frame Data and camera images

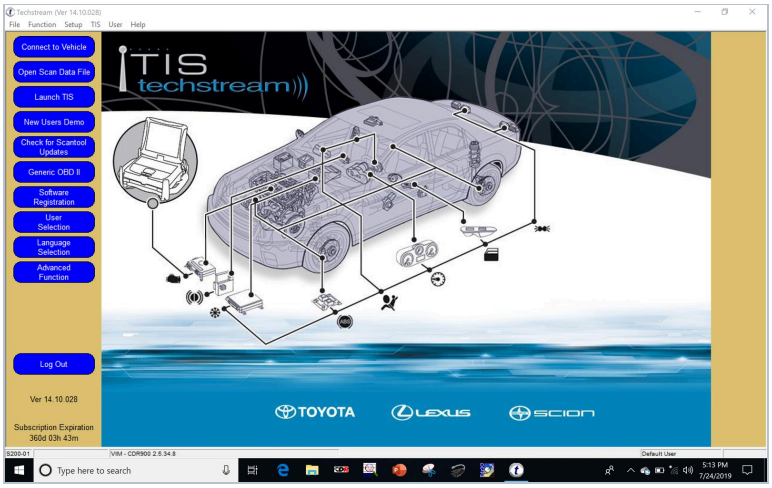
Field procedure, at the vehicle. Revised September 2026 · Screenshots after Brad Muir / Crash Data Specialists and E. Clarke / CHP MAIT.

Before you start

- Confirm you have lawful authority to retrieve the data. Some states require the owner's written consent.
- Confirm the TIS subscription is active — Professional Diagnostics, not Standard.
- Retrieve as early as practical. VCH records overwrite; every key cycle risks losing data.
- Have a booster or supply battery ready. A read can take 1–90 minutes.
- Photograph the vehicle, VIN plate, odometer and DLC, and note laptop clock vs. actual time.
- **Screen-capture every screen below as you go.** The captures cannot be recreated later.

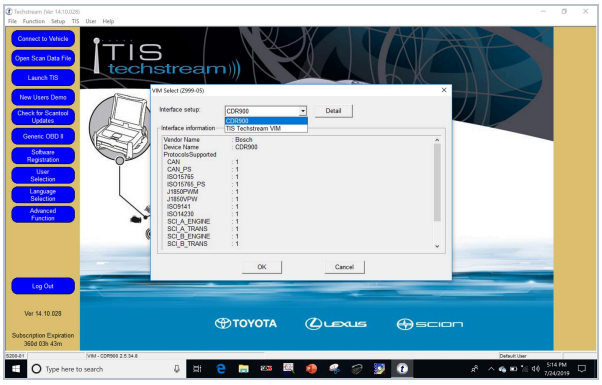
1. Check for 12 volts at the battery. Turn the ignition **ON** — do not start the engine. Connect the VIM to the DLC and to the laptop.

2. Launch Techstream and **capture the main screen**: software version, remaining subscription time (lower left) and the active VIM in the status bar.



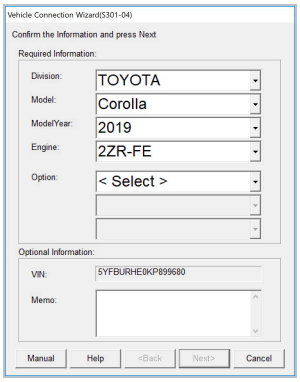
Step 2 — Techstream main screen.

3. Click **Setup → VIM Select**, choose the interface you are using, and click **OK**. Capture the selection.



Step 3 — VIM Select.

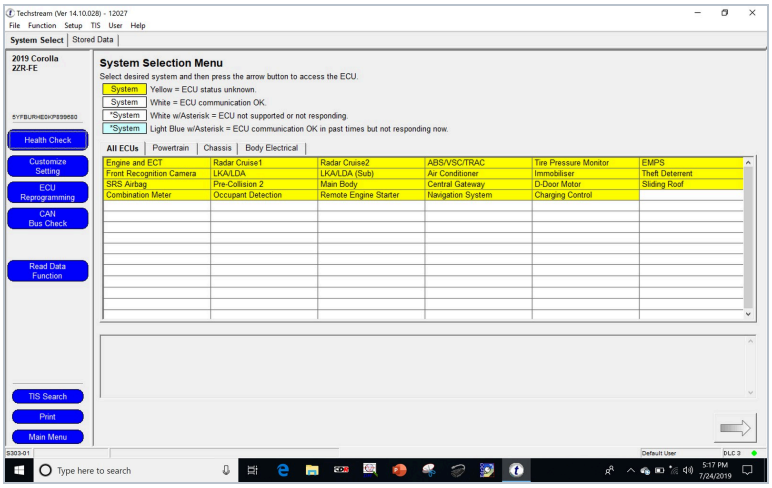
4. Click **Connect to Vehicle**. Confirm the auto-detected Division, Model, Model Year and Engine, set any options the vehicle carries, add a case note in the Memo field, and click **Next**. **Capture this screen** — it is your record that the tool was connected to this VIN.



Step 4 — confirm vehicle information and VIN.

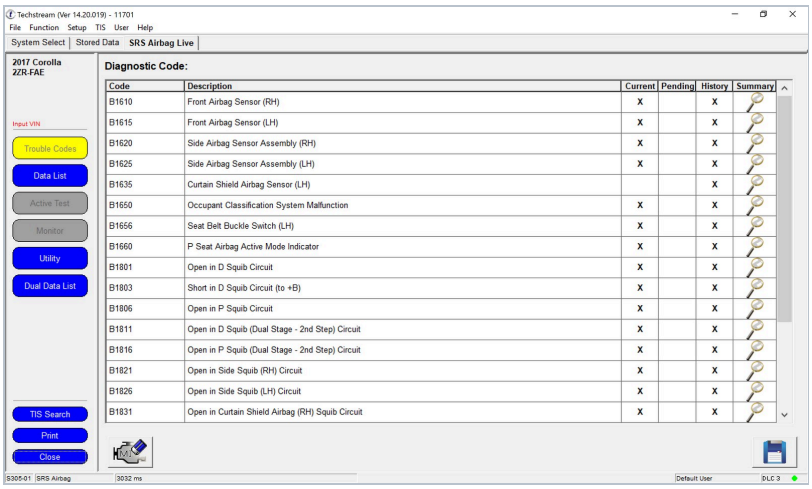
> **Connecting manually (D2M)? Type the VIN yourself.** Techstream builds the retrieval file name from the VIN; a blank or wrong VIN gives a mismatch error and a misnamed file.

5. At the System Selection Menu, run **Health Check** to bus-scan the vehicle, save or print the report, and capture the menu as your record of the ECU inventory.



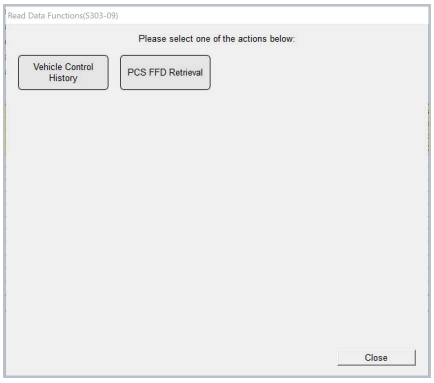
Step 5 — System Selection Menu after a Health Check.

6. Open **SRS Airbag** and click **Trouble Codes**. Save with the disk icon and capture the current, pending and history codes. Then click **Data List** and save and capture that too.



Step 6 — SRS Airbag diagnostic codes.

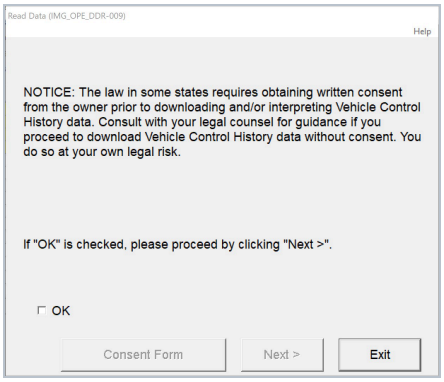
7. Return to the **System Select** tab, click **Read Data Function**, and choose **PCS FFD Retrieval**.



Step 7 — choose PCS FFD Retrieval.

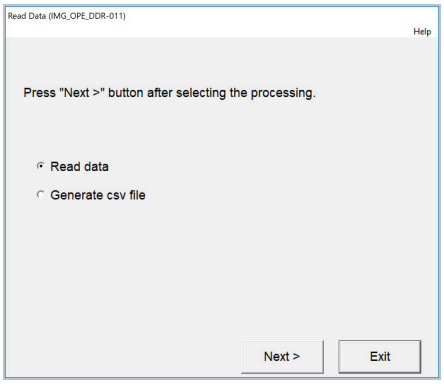
> **Not the Vehicle Control History button.** That path retrieves VCH only. PCS FFD Retrieval gets the Vehicle Control History *and* the camera images.

8. Read the legal notice, **tick OK**, and click **Next**. Capture the screen.



Step 8 — consent notice; Next stays greyed out until OK is ticked.

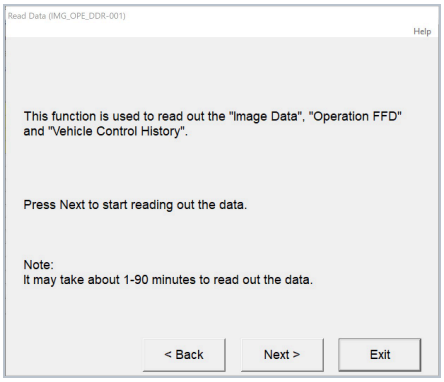
9 Select **Read data** and click **Next**.



Step 9 — choose Read data.

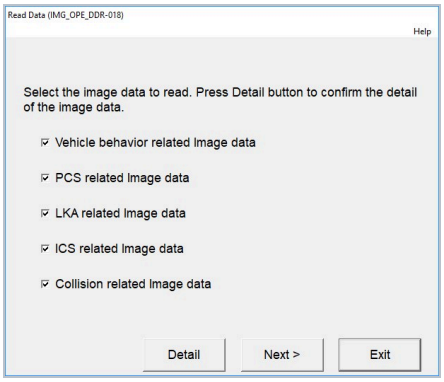
> **Do not choose “Generate csv file” here.** It does not retrieve the image data. CSV output comes later, from the saved file.

10 Techstream confirms it will read out Image Data, Operation FFD and Vehicle Control History, and warns the read may take 1–90 minutes. Confirm your power supply will last, then click **Next**.



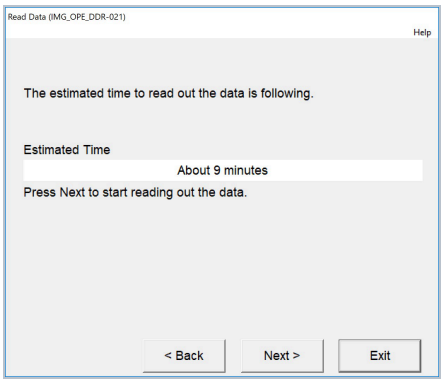
Step 10 — read-out confirmation.

11 Select the image data to read and **check every box offered** — five categories on a TSS 2.0 vehicle, one on TSS 1.0. Capture the screen so the requested categories are recorded, then click **Next**.



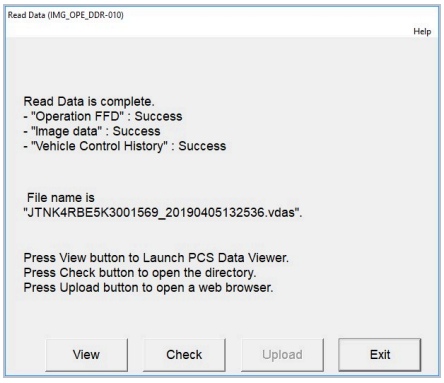
Step 11 — TSS 2.0 image selection. TSS 1.0 offers only PCS related Image data.

12 Check the estimated read time against your power and available time, then click **Next** to start. Do not disturb the laptop or the connection while it runs.



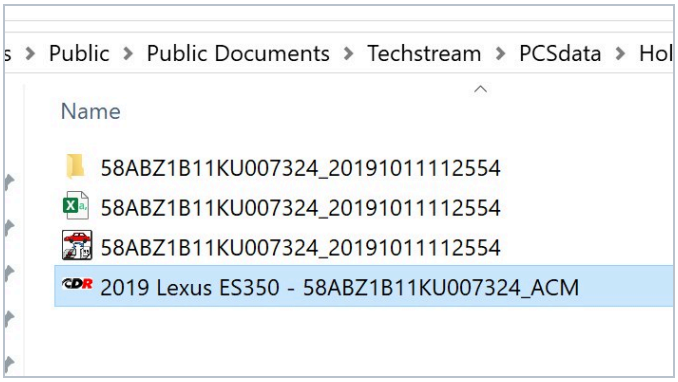
Step 12 — estimated read time.

13 **Capture the completion screen. This is the most important capture of the retrieval.** It reports the status of all three data sets and names the file created. `Image data : N/A` means no images were stored — a finding, not a failure.



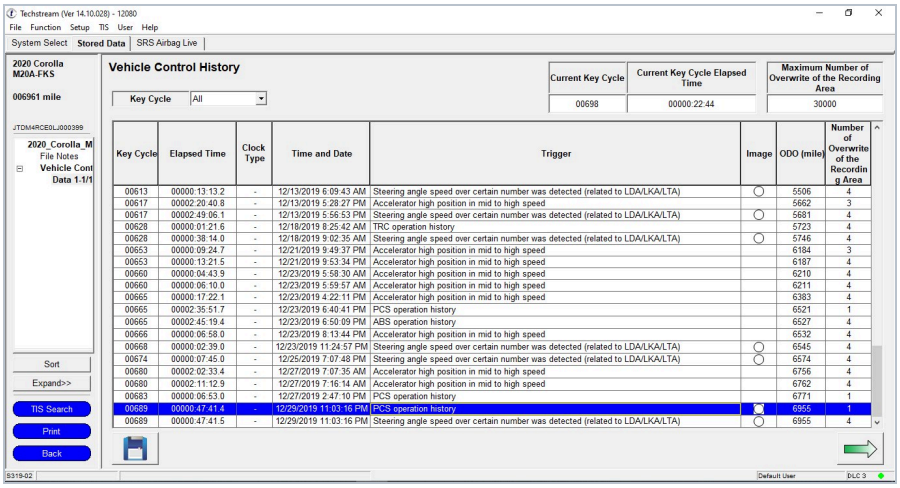
Step 13 — file name follows `VIN_YYYYMMDDHHMMSS.vdas`.

14 Click **Check**. Explorer opens at the save folder, by default `C:\Users\Public\Public Documents\Techstream\PCSdata\`. Confirm the `.vdas` file is there and note the full path.



Step 14 — the retrieval file on disk.

15 Still on scene, open the **Stored Data** tab to review the event list — key cycle, elapsed time, date and time, trigger, odometer and overwrite count. **A circle in the Image column marks an event with camera images.** Note the key cycles relevant to your investigation, and use the disk icon to export the list.



Step 15 — VCH event list; disk icon (lower left) exports it.

16 Open each relevant event to see its parameters and trigger note, and export it with the **disk icon**.



Step 16 — individual trigger event.

> **The Excel export does not include the camera images.** Images come out only through the PCS Data Viewer output, done later from the `.vdas` file — and only while the subscription is still active.

17 **Copy the `.vdas` file and every screen capture to external media.** Open the copy and check its size before you disconnect. Work the table below, then exit Techstream, disconnect the VIM and switch the ignition off.

Files You Should Have Before Leaving the Inspection

Do not disconnect until every row is accounted for. Where a row is not applicable, record *why* in your notes rather than leaving it blank.

No.	File	Location	Save Method
1	Software version and subscription expiration	Techstream main screen at launch	Screen capture
2	Interface (VIM) selection	Setup → VIM Select	Screen capture
3	Vehicle identification and VIN	Vehicle Connection Wizard	Screen capture
4	ECU inventory / System Selection Menu	System Select tab	Screen capture
5	Health Check report	System Select → Health Check	Save / print to PDF
6	SRS Airbag diagnostic trouble codes	SRS Airbag → Trouble Codes	Save (disk icon) + screen capture
7	SRS Airbag data list	SRS Airbag → Data List	Save (disk icon) + screen capture
8	Consent notice as acknowledged	Read Data (IMG_OPE_DDR-009)	Screen capture
9	Image data categories requested	Read Data image selection screen	Screen capture
10	Read-out estimated time	Read Data (IMG_OPE_DDR-021)	Screen capture
11	**Read Data complete summary** — status of Operation FFD, Image data and Vehicle Control History, plus the file name	Read Data (IMG_OPE_DDR-010)	Screen capture
12	**Retrieval file** `VIN_YYYYMMDDHHMMSS.vdas`	`C:\Users\Public\Public Documents\Techstream\PCSdata\`	Copy to external media
13	Vehicle Control History event list	Stored Data → Vehicle Control History	Export (disk icon) to Excel + screen capture
14	Individual trigger event data, for each relevant event	VCH list → event → disk icon	Export to Excel + screen capture
15	Photographs of vehicle, VIN plate, odometer and DLC; laptop clock vs. actual time	Scene	Camera / notes

Next, off the vehicle: load the `.vdas` file into PCS Data Viewer and run **File → Output PCS Data** to produce the CSV, image and PDF output. Do this *before the TIS subscription expires* — once it does, the `.vdas` file can no longer be opened. Those steps are in the full *Toyota Techstream Imaging Guide*.